

KB0004 — SSO / SAML Login Failures

Category: Identity & Access Management

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Owner: Platform Engineering

Overview

This article covers SSO login failures for SAML 2.0 and OIDC integrations, including Okta-brokered logins to third-party apps (Salesforce, ServiceNow, Workday, GitHub Enterprise).

Symptoms

- "SAML response not valid" error after Okta login
 - "You do not have access to this application" after correct credentials
 - SSO redirect loop (keeps returning to login page)
 - Error: "InResponseTo mismatch" or "Audience mismatch"
 - User can login via Okta but app says "unauthorized"
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Root Causes

1. **Clock skew between IdP and SP** — SAML assertions are time-sensitive; >5 min skew causes rejection.
 2. **Attribute mapping mismatch** — App expects `email` attribute but Okta sends `login`.
 3. **Expired or rotated certificate** — Okta signing certificate expired or SP hasn't imported new cert.
 4. **User not assigned to application** — Okta app assignment missing for user or group.
 5. **SP metadata stale** — Service Provider has outdated Okta metadata (entityID, ACS URL changed).
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Diagnostic Steps

Check Okta System Log

```
Okta Admin → Reports → System Log
Filter: Event Type = "user.authentication.sso"
Look for: failure events with error codes
```

Common Error Codes

Code	Meaning	Fix
E0000095	App not assigned	Add user/group to app
E0000047	Rate limit	Wait or request limit increase
E0000011	Invalid token	Clear session, retry
SAML_SIGNATURE_INVALID	Cert mismatch	Rotate/reimport certificate

Validate SAML Response

1. Install SAML Tracer browser extension
 2. Capture failed login attempt
 3. Inspect NameID, attributes, and Conditions (NotBefore/NotOnOrAfter)
 4. Compare against app's expected attribute schema
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Resolution Steps

App Assignment Fix

```
Okta Admin → Applications → [App Name] → Assignments tab
→ Add user or group → Save
```

Certificate Rotation

```
Okta Admin → Applications → [App Name] → Sign On tab  
→ SAML Signing Certificates → Generate new certificate  
→ Download new cert → Import into SP (ServiceNow/Salesforce admin)  
→ Activate new cert in Okta → Test login
```

Attribute Mapping Fix

```
Okta Admin → Applications → [App Name] → Sign On → Edit  
→ Attributes (Optional) → Add/correct attribute name and value  
Example: Name = "email", Value = "${user.email}"
```

Clock Skew Fix (SP side)

- Ensure SP server is NTP-synced
- Okta has ± 5 min tolerance by default; configure SP to match
- ServiceNow: System Properties → glide.saml.clock.skew = 300

Testing Checklist

- ☐ User assigned to app in Okta
- ☐ Certificate valid and imported on SP
- ☐ Attribute mapping matches SP schema
- ☐ SP and IdP clocks within 5 minutes
- ☐ SP metadata is current

Related Articles

- KB0001 — Password Reset & Account Unlock Procedures
- KB0002 — MFA Enrollment and Troubleshooting